

Compare and contrast the issues faced by instructional designers who come into a system for a short period of time. Discuss whether you believe internal or external instructional designers have the most chance of success and in what situations.

In a development project team, it is always better to work on the project from the very beginning. From the funding period to the start of the project, it is best to have the whole team in place. As we have already discovered in the first two case studies by Ertmer and Quinn (2007), they discuss project management and instructional design. We have seen that the project manager's role is to assemble a team with the necessary skill sets and experience to work on the project. Depending on the project's complexity and instructional design strategies, one or more instructional designers may be assigned to the project. The organizational structure of the Our Nation and Society Project (pg. 14) is typical of a team structure. Instructional designers (s) and other specialists make up the design team.

An instructional designer is a person who develops instructional content for learning. He/she needs to ensure that specific learning goals are accomplished. Responsibilities of an instructional designer include the following (wikipedia.com):

- 1) Analyze - analyze learner characteristics, task to be learned, etc.
- 2) Design - develop learning objectives, choose an instructional approach
- 3) Develop - create instructional or training materials
- 4) Implement - deliver or distribute the instructional materials
- 5) Evaluate - make sure the materials achieved the desired goals

If you have worked in a project team before, you may be familiar with these activities, which are part of the project development lifecycle. The project development lifecycle is a multidisciplinary organizational effort that often involves many people inside and outside the group and requires different skills at different times. The issues and challenges start off numerous and evolve throughout the project.

I believe that any project team or instructional design is a team effort. In the case of ID, no instructional designer works alone. If any team members, not just the instructional designer, are missing, it is critical to the project and results in lost productivity and the cost of backfill and replacement.

For all the reasons above, an instructional designer entering a system for a short period is bound to encounter problems and may jeopardize the quality of the design. Ideally, he/she starts the project from the very beginning. Depending on where the development lifecycle, the earlier, the better.

As for whether internal or external instructional designers are more likely to succeed, I think it depends on the kind of project. In some cases, it is good to have new thinking (new blood) and new ideas brought to the project. In other cases, it may be better to have a person (ID) who is already familiar with the project. So, my answer depends on the project and available expertise and staff.

When we lose a member of a team, it can negatively impact the project's outcome. In the industry, this is known as staff turnover. Does a high turnover create extra work? I think so.

An article by Oglesby (2003) discusses the problem of new teachers leaving the classroom after three years, with 50 percent quitting after five. It's a problem and a burden not only for schools, students, teachers, and staff.

Instructional Design from http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Instructional_design
Christy Oglesby(2003), Teachers: low pay, low morale, high turnover from
<http://www.cnn.com/SPECIALS/2001/schools/stories/staff.effects.html>

Ben Leubsdorf(2007), The Problem With Term Limits from
<http://chronicle.com/weekly/v52/i47/47a01301.htm>

Dan Curry and Susannah Dainow, Colgate U. President Unexpectedly Quits; Faculty Exodus Strikes Criminal-Justice Program at Northeastern U. from
<http://chronicle.com/weekly/v47/i42/42a00901.htm>

Lin Response:

I personally like Gagné's nine instructional events; I think that designing the external instructional events can affect the internal learning process.

The following are the external instructional events that affect the internal learning process that Gagne proposed

- Gaining attention: To ensure reception of coming instruction, we give the learner a stimulus.
- Tell learners the learning objective: Tell the learner what they will be able to do because of the instruction.
- Stimulating recall of prior learning: Ask for recall of existing relevant knowledge.
- Presenting the stimulus: Display the content.
- Providing learning guidance: Help understanding (semantic encoding) by providing organization & relevance.
- Eliciting performance: Ask the learner to respond, demonstrating learning
- Providing feedback: Give informative feedback on the learner's performance.
- Assessing performance: Require more learner performance and give feedback to reinforce learning.
- Enhancing retention and transfer to other contexts: Provide varied practice to generalize the capability

I think instructional designers should be able to design instructional projects to enhance learners' motivation and learning outcomes. Sometimes, when we design the project, we often forget the goals of designing the project and design the "ideal" project which cannot achieve the expectation

My Response:

Thanks for the information on Gagne's nice instructional events. Yet, this is another form of the development process of instructional design (or lifecycle). Thanks for reminding us the importance of the learning outcome of any instructional design.

Dr. Butler:

Hi Jim,

Another home run this week with your response to the DB prompt! I very much enjoyed your very clear description of the roles and duties of the project manager in an ID team. I also liked what you said here:

For all the reasons above, an instructional designer to come into a system for short period of time bounds to have problem and may jeopardize the quality of the design. Ideally, he/she starts the project from the very beginning. Depending on where in development lifecycle, the earlier in development lifecycle is better.

I agree with you, the sooner the instructional designer is brought into the project, the better the design. In your experience, in your experiences, can you share with us any tips for an instructional designer who is brought in late to a project?

Thanks Jim for another outstanding week.

~Kim

What are some of the reasons that the instructional designer isn't brought in sooner for a project?

This is a very complex problem and depending on the complexity of instructional design project. Instructional designer is good to go if the requirements and learning objectives are well defined. He/she may not be as productive if he/she has to do requirements gathering. Instructional designer job is analyzing the requirements (learning objectives) and come up with the learning strategies. In case 2, we have seemed that Denny has problem getting his project going. I think that this is the same problem.

In case of an instructional designer who is brought in late to a project, I think that he/she needs to get up to speed fairly quick that include analyze the requirements, learning objectives, and strategies. Before any of these objectives, he/she need to identify who are the stakeholders. In ideal person must be well round person, team player, and working under stress. Depending on how late into the project, he/she must have done this kind of project or very closely related project.

Perri Response

What are some of the reasons that the instructional designer isn't brought in sooner for a project?

I would also add to Jim's comments that other reasons might reflect the sentiment that it's easier said than done to: "get up to speed quickly"; to "identify the stakeholders"; and to be a "well rounded team player who works well under stress." It reminds me of the facetious ads for the "30 year old with 50 years of experience." Sometimes just getting the learning objectives clarified is the major hurdle with the view that these kill spontaneity, serendipity and hem in what would otherwise be a student-led learning experience. This can be done, of course, but sometimes the devil is in the details.